Riverside Community Library

2025 Annual Service Report

Prepared for the Library Board and the Riverside Neighbourhood Council. This report covers the calendar year from 1 January to 31 December 2025 and describes visits, collections, programmes, facilities, staffing, spending and the priorities proposed for 2026.

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1. Director's Summary

2025 was the first full year after the reading room renovation. The library recorded 118,460 visits, an increase of 9.4 percent on 2024, and issued 1,912 new library cards. Weekday afternoons remained the busiest period, while Saturday morning family sessions grew faster than any other time slot.

Three results stand out. First, digital lending passed print lending for adult fiction for the first time, reaching 51 percent of adult fiction loans in the fourth quarter. Second, the seniors' digital help desk answered 2,340 enquiries, most of them about online banking, health appointments and photo sharing. Third, the building closed unexpectedly on only two days, both caused by the heating fault in January.

Spending finished at 98.2 percent of the approved budget. The small underspend came from a delayed furniture order that will be delivered in February 2026. No programme was cancelled for financial reasons.

The board is asked to note the results in this report and to approve the four priorities for 2026 set out in Section 8: extended Thursday opening, a homework club for secondary students, replacement of the self-service kiosks, and a second accessible entrance on the river side of the building.

Staff and volunteers carried this year. I thank the 46 volunteers who gave 5,180 hours, the friends' group for funding the summer reading prizes, and our neighbours who sent 312 suggestions through the comment box. Several of those suggestions are already in place, including the quiet study tables near the periodicals shelf.

2. Visits and Membership

Visits are counted by the door sensor at the main entrance and checked each month against a manual two-hour sample. The sensor under-counted by about 2 percent during the January heating repairs, when the side door was used; those days were corrected from the manual sample.

Month	Visits	New cards	Wi-Fi sessions
January	8,420	141	2,210
February	8,975	152	2,304
March	9,840	168	2,611
April	9,310	149	2,490
May	9,655	155	2,552
June	9,120	133	2,398
July	11,380	214	2,804
August	11,720	226	2,851
September	10,240	181	2,730
October	10,010	162	2,688
November	9,790	143	2,575
December	10,000	88	2,312
Total	118,460	1912	30,525

July and August were the busiest months because of the summer reading challenge and the cooling room provided during the heat warning in late July. December fell slightly after the 20th because of the holiday opening hours.

Active membership, defined as at least one loan or computer booking in the last twelve months, stood at 7,904 at year end. Forty-one percent of active members live within one kilometre of the library. Card registrations from the new housing on Wharf Road rose steadily after the welcome leaflet was delivered in April.

3. Collections and Circulation

Total loans reached 164,300 items. The collection grew by 4,880 items and 3,120 worn or outdated items were withdrawn, following the collection policy agreed in 2023.

Format	Loans 2024	Loans 2025	Change
Adult print	61,240	58,910	-3.8%
Children's print	47,880	50,360	+5.2%
E-books	24,130	29,870	+23.8%
Audiobooks	11,460	14,120	+23.2%
DVD and games	4,050	3,410	-15.8%
Interlibrary loan	1,410	1,630	+15.6%

3.1 Print collection

Children's picture books and early readers remain the most borrowed print category. The board books for under-threes were refreshed in May and loans in that category doubled during the summer.

Large print titles were moved closer to the entrance after feedback from the seniors' group. Loans of large print rose by 11 percent in the second half of the year.

3.2 Digital lending

Digital lending continued to grow. The waiting list for popular e-books averaged 19 days, down from 31 days, after additional licences were purchased in June. Audiobook use is highest among commuters and is concentrated on Monday and Friday mornings.

Licence costs per loan remain about three times higher than print. The 2026 budget keeps the digital allocation at the 2025 level and relies on shorter licence terms for very popular titles.

3.3 Interlibrary loan

Readers requested 1,630 items from partner libraries, with a median delivery time of six days. Ninety-four percent of requests were fulfilled. Most unfulfilled requests were for out-of-print local history titles; the local history group has offered to scan two of these for the archive.

4. Programmes and Outreach

The library ran 612 sessions with 14,950 attendances. Programmes are free unless materials are provided; materials fees were waived for 186 children through the friends' group fund.

4.1 Children and families

Rhyme time ran twice weekly and averaged 38 attendees per session. The summer reading challenge enrolled 1,140 children, of whom 702 completed six books. Completion was highest among children aged seven to nine.

The Saturday morning family session moved to the renovated reading room in March. Attendance nearly doubled after the move, so a second session will begin in January 2026.

4.2 Adult learning

English conversation groups met on Tuesday and Thursday evenings with a volunteer coordinator. Job search clinics were held fortnightly in partnership with the employment service; 64 participants reported finding work or training within three months.

4.3 Seniors' digital help

The seniors' digital help desk opened four mornings a week. Of the 2,340 enquiries, 38 percent concerned online banking, 22 percent health appointments, 17 percent photos and messaging, and the rest a mix of forms, travel bookings and device settings.

Volunteers report that a fixed appointment slot works better than drop-in visits for longer problems. From February 2026, thirty-minute appointments can be booked at the front desk.

5. Facilities and Safety

The building was open on 301 of 303 scheduled days. The two unplanned closures were on 14 and 15 January, when the heating system failed during cold weather.

5.1 Building maintenance

The boiler control board was replaced in January and the system has run without fault since. Roof gutters were cleared in October. The lift passed its six-monthly inspections in April and October. Two reading room windows need new seals before winter 2026.

5.2 Incident summary

Staff recorded 27 incidents, compared with 31 in 2024. Nineteen were minor first-aid cases, five were lost-property disputes and three were disruptive behaviour that ended without police involvement. No incident caused a serious injury.

Category	2024	2025
Minor first aid	21	19
Lost property	6	5
Disruptive behaviour	4	3

5.3 Closing checklist

Before closing, the duty supervisor walks the building with the closing checklist. The check covers the study rooms, toilets and lift, the public computers, the kitchen equipment in the community room and all external doors.

Public computers must be logged out and shut down by 19:45. The cash box is counted with a second member of staff and placed in the safe. Any fault is written in the handover book so the opening team can follow it up the next morning.

The alarm is set only after the supervisor has confirmed that no visitor remains in the building. If the alarm cannot be set, the supervisor calls the facilities contractor and waits on site.

6. Staffing and Volunteers

The library employs 11.6 full-time-equivalent staff. One senior librarian retired in June and the post was filled internally in August. Staff completed 212 hours of training, including first aid renewal, safeguarding and an introduction to the new catalogue system.

Forty-six volunteers gave 5,180 hours. The largest groups support the digital help desk, the summer reading challenge and the home delivery service, which brought books to 58 housebound readers every three weeks.

Sickness absence averaged 4.1 days per employee. Staff survey responses rated team communication highly but asked for more notice of rota changes; rotas are now published four weeks in advance.

7. Budget and Spending

The approved budget for 2025 was 1,236,000. Actual spending was 1,213,700, or 98.2 percent of the budget.

Line	Budget	Actual	Variance
Staff	742,000	739,400	-2,600
Collections	188,000	187,150	-850
Building and utilities	171,000	176,900	+5,900
Programmes	64,000	62,300	-1,700
IT and kiosks	45,000	41,950	-3,050
Furniture	26,000	6,000	-20,000
Total	1,236,000	1,213,700	-22,300

Building costs were above budget because of the emergency boiler repair. The furniture underspend reflects the delayed order for study tables, which is now committed for February 2026.

8. Priorities for 2026

The board is asked to approve the following four priorities, which can be delivered within the proposed 2026 budget.

Extended Thursday opening. Open until 21:00 on Thursdays from April, staffed by moving two existing evening shifts. Expected benefit: easier access for people who work during the day.

Homework club for secondary students. Two afternoons a week in the community room, supported by volunteer tutors and the local secondary school.

Self-service kiosk replacement. The three kiosks are out of support at the end of 2026. Replacement is scheduled for the summer, when visits are high but the building is less crowded in the mornings.

Second accessible entrance. A ramped entrance on the river side, subject to planning consent. The design study will be presented to the board in June.

Appendix A. Data Notes

Visit counts come from the entrance sensor and are corrected with manual samples where the sensor was bypassed. Loans include renewals made in person but exclude automatic renewals. Programme attendance counts each person at each session. Financial figures are unaudited management accounts at 31 December 2025.

Figures in this report are rounded where stated. Percentages are calculated from unrounded totals.